family enormously. If only our parents were alive to see what you have achieved. How happy and proud they would have been.' I wiped her tears gently and tried to console her, 'Who can fight fate? Perhaps I would never have reached such pinnacles of success if I hadn't endured those early days of austerity and adversity.'

My sister was unaware of the little surprise I had planned for her. I asked her to put on my India blazer. Once she did, I asked her to put her hands in the side pockets of the blazer. I had put a gold earring in each of the pockets. 'These are for you', I told her. She took the earrings and just couldn't stop crying.

Inside the stadium, I ordered tea and fruit for my family, but Isher demurred saying, 'Why are you going through all this trouble for us? We've already had tea.' Her simple remarks filled me with affection as I led them into the stadium. As we entered, I felt the crowd staring at their simple attire with disdain. For a moment I felt embarrassed, but then was filled with loathing at people's snobbish attitudes. With great love and consideration I made them sit in the best seats and stayed with them until my event began.

Isher asked me where I would run and I pointed to the track, and patiently explained that the athlete who would reach the winning post first would receive a medal, which added to his glory as a sportsman. When I entered the field, Isher tried to keep her eyes fixed on me throughout the duration of the race. I came first as usual, but fainted yet again because of the energy I had expended while running. My poor sister thought that I had been shot dead by the gun that had started the race. She started wailing loudly when she saw me being carried away on a stretcher. The other spectators attempted to reassure her, but she was not convinced and demanded that she be taken to me immediately. When she saw me lying down looking pale, with a film of glucose on my lips, she cried, 'I can't bear to see you in this condition. *Veer* (brother), please, I beg you, give up running.'

When I recovered, we returned to the stadium to be greeted by vociferous cheers. I nudged Isher and remarked, 'Look at the honour and praise I receive when I run and win races. If I stop running, no one will bother about me.' But she was still not convinced.

The National Games were held for three days, during which I set new records—100 metres (10.4); 200 metres (20.8); 400 metres (46.1); 4×100-metre relay (42.1); and 4×400-metre relay (3.12.6).